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I was invited to give the convocation address at my alma mater, the Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi. As I pondered over what I would say, I realized that the graduating students were young enough to be my children. What message would I give my children at this time, a message that would challenge as well as inspire them, as convocation speeches are meant to do? It could not be another speech on economics – that might educate but not inspire. The moment made the choice of topic clear. There was a raging debate in India in late 2015 on the issue of tolerance, and this is what I decided to speak on. I explained to the young graduating scholars that India's strength is her enduring tradition of tolerance and debate, and that it will be our source of comparative economic advantage as we approach the frontiers of innovation. This is the speech I delivered on 31 October 2015.

Tolerance and Respect: Essentials for Economic Progress

Thank you very much for inviting me back to the Institute to deliver the convocation address. I graduated with a degree in Electrical Engineering thirty years ago. I was overly anxious then about what the future held for me, because I did not realize that the Institute had prepared me so well for what lay ahead. Our professors – and I will not single out any to avoid a disservice to those I do not name – were dedicated professionals. They asked a lot of us, knowing that in challenging us they allowed us to learn what we were capable of. Equally important, our Electrical Engineering class – in those days, Computer Science was part of Electrical Engineering in IIT Delhi – had some of the smartest people it has been my privilege to know. After working with them as colleagues, and competing with them for grades, I learned what it took to succeed in the fiercest environments;